

Practice Paper 14 — Answer Scheme

Paper 2 — Comprehension

Sections B & C

Note to teachers and students

- Marks are awarded for **meaning**, not for exact words. Where a quotation is required, it has been indicated in inverted commas.
- Where the question asks for **own words**, a candidate who lifts directly from the text receives **zero** for that mark unless the lifted phrase is unavoidable.
- For language and tone questions, accept any reasonable alternative that clearly fits the textual evidence.

Section B — Text 3 Answer Scheme [20 marks]

Q1. [2] — State of mind before the meeting

1 mark for identifying that he was **anxious** / **preoccupied** / **nervous** about meeting his brother.
1 mark for explaining that arriving early was a way of **hiding** this anxiety from himself — pretending he had been unaffected when in fact the meeting had weighed on him for weeks.

Sample answer: The narrator was, in truth, **nervous** and had been **dwelling on the meeting** for some time, but he tried to convince himself that he was calm by arriving early, as though punctuality could disguise how much the encounter mattered to him.

Q2. [2] — Real feelings about not returning to the grave

1 mark — He is offering an **excuse** (distance) which he himself does not fully believe.
1 mark — The hedged phrase “not, in any meaningful sense, my fault” suggests **guilt** / he knows he **could** have visited and is **rationalising** his absence.

Q3. [2] — The handshake “counted as an embrace”

1 mark — The brothers are **emotionally distant** / **unable to show affection openly**.
1 mark — Even a slightly prolonged handshake is, **for them**, an unusually warm gesture — showing how **guarded** and **formal** their relationship has become.

Q4. [2] — Awkwardness of the conversation

1 mark each for any two of:

- The dialogue consists of **very short, clipped exchanges** (“You found it all right, then.” / “I found it.”).
- They look at the headstone rather than at each other.
- The narrator “could not think of a single sentence that did not feel either too small or too large for the moment.”

- The pauses are filled by external details (the robin, the distant lawnmower), suggesting nothing personal is being said.

Q5. [1] — Effect of the word **mercifully**

1 mark — It suggests **relief**: the brothers were **uncomfortable** looking at each other directly, so the headstone provided a welcome **distraction** / **escape** from eye contact.

Q6. [2] — “As plainly as the headstone”

1 mark — The comparison makes the **old quarrel** feel as **solid, visible and unavoidable** as the physical stone in front of them.

1 mark — It also links the quarrel to the **father’s death** — both the grave and the grievance are now permanent, fixed parts of the brothers’ shared landscape.

Q7. [2] — “An animal we had agreed, for the moment, not to wake”

1 mark — The image suggests the quarrel is **dangerous** / **alive**: if disturbed it could **attack** them and ruin the meeting.

1 mark — “For the moment” shows the agreement is only **temporary** — the quarrel is **not resolved**, only **postponed**; it remains capable of waking up later.

Q8. [2] — “Tired gratitude” towards Daniel

1 mark — Daniel was the **first to name** the quarrel and to **defer** it openly, sparing them both the strain of pretending.

1 mark — **Tired** suggests the narrator is **exhausted** by their estrangement; he is grateful because his brother showed a **courage** he himself had not been able to muster.

Q9. [2] — “The solemnity of a man knighting a son”

1 mark — It suggests the father took **small family occasions extremely seriously** and treated them with **grand ceremony**.

1 mark — It also suggests he was an **affectionate, slightly comic figure** who delighted in **little rituals** of fatherhood — making him feel warm and present, even in memory.

Q10. [2] — Why the smile is significant

1 mark — The smile did not **resolve** the quarrel or undo eight years of distance — it was small and limited.

1 mark — But it was the **first warm, uncomplicated exchange** between them since the estrangement: “the first thing in eight years that had passed from his face to mine without anything sharp attached to it.” This makes it **symbolically important** — a small thawing of the silence.

Q11. [1] — Tone of the final sentence

1 mark — Any **one** of: **quietly hopeful**, **tentatively reconciled**, **gently relieved**, **cautiously warm**. (Reject: **joyful**, **triumphant** — these overstate the moment; reject **sad** — this misses the small recovery.)

Section C — Text 4 Answer Scheme [25 marks]

Q12. [2] — “The label was new. The thing it described was not.”

1 mark — The **term** “quiet quitting” was a **recent invention** (coined in 2022 by Zaid Khan).

1 mark — But the **underlying behaviour** — workers limiting their effort to the contracted role — had **existed long before** the phrase was coined.

Q13. [2] — Why **quitting** is “metaphorical”

1 mark — The worker has **not actually resigned** / they remain in their job and continue to be paid.

1 mark — What they have **abandoned** is the **unspoken cultural expectation** of going beyond the contract, not the post itself.

Q14. [2] — Two examples of “the unspoken expectation”

1 mark each for any two of:

- Working **an hour or two beyond the contracted day**.
- **Answering messages** that arrive late in the evening (e.g. at nine).
- Treating such **extra effort** as a **normal cost of being taken seriously** at work.

Q15. [2] — “Generational, though not exclusively so”

1 mark — Quiet quitting is **most strongly seen among younger workers** — particularly those under thirty-five.

1 mark — **However**, it is **not confined to them**: workers of other generations are affected as well, even if to a lesser degree.

Q16. [2] — Two economic reasons younger workers are disengaging

1 mark each for any two of:

- **Wages** have **not kept up** with the **cost of housing**.
- The **promotion ladders** that once **justified extra hours** have been **quietly removed** in many firms.
- The **pandemic** showed workers that the workplaces they had been pouring themselves into could **disappear overnight** / be folded up in a fortnight.

Q17. [1] — Inverted commas around **lazy** and **entitled**

1 mark — The writer is **quoting** the language used by **senior executives** and **distancing himself** from the judgement / signalling that these are **other people’s words**, not his own view. (Also accept: he is **sceptical** of those labels.)

Q18. [2] — Trust no longer the default

1 mark — Employers no longer **assume** that their staff are working honestly; they require **evidence** of effort.

1 mark — Workers' **productivity** is now **monitored and measured** through software, rather than being **trusted** on the basis of professional good faith. This implies a **more suspicious, controlling** attitude.

Q19. [1] — Attitude towards surveillance-first employers

1 mark — **Critical / disapproving / sceptical**. (Also accept: **quietly censorious, dismissive**. Reject: **neutral, supportive**.)

Q20. [2] — One defender's point and one critic's point

1 mark — **Defenders:** Quiet quitting is **healthy boundary-setting**; doing one's job well and then living one's life is **not a moral failing**; older generations were too **anxious** or **grateful** to set such limits.

1 mark — **Critics:** A workforce that **refuses on principle** to go beyond the contract has **stopped believing in the work**; this is **bad for workers as well as employers**, because **meaning** at work comes from the **small acts of going beyond**.

Q21. [2] — "The quietest form of quitting is, in fact, the loudest"

1 mark — It uses a **paradox / contrast** between **quiet** and **loud** to draw attention to the warning.

1 mark — It suggests that although individual workers withdraw their extra effort **silently**, the **collective signal** — to firms that ignore the problem — is unmistakable and **impossible to overlook**; the effect on the business will, in time, be **very loud indeed**.

Q22. Summary [13 marks total: 6 content + 7 style]

Content points ($\frac{1}{2}$ mark each, max 6 marks). **Eight available content points; candidates should aim for all 8.**

Why workers, especially younger ones, are quietly quitting (Paragraphs 3–5):

1. **Engagement** with employers has fallen to a **decade low**, with the sharpest drop **since the pandemic**.
2. **Wages** have **failed to keep pace** with the **cost of housing**.
3. The **promotion ladders** that once rewarded extra hours have been **quietly removed**.
4. The **pandemic** showed workers that their workplaces could **vanish overnight**, making heavy personal investment feel unwise.
5. The behaviour is, more honestly, a sign of **burnout** — workers being **asked for more** than the firm openly admits.

How employers have responded (Paragraphs 4–5):

6. Some senior leaders have publicly **denounced** quiet quitters as **lazy** or **entitled**.
7. Many firms have installed **surveillance software** that **tracks keystrokes and active hours** and alerts managers when activity stops.
8. A smaller number have begun to **renegotiate** the terms of work — **clearer job descriptions, protected time off**, and managers who **model** a sensible end to the day.

Sample full-marks summary (78 words):

Many workers, particularly younger ones, are quietly quitting because engagement has fallen sharply since the pandemic, wages have lagged behind housing costs, and the promotions that once justified long hours have disappeared; many are simply burnt out. Employers have reacted in opposing ways. Some leaders have publicly attacked quiet quitters as lazy, while many firms have installed monitoring software to track activity. A minority, however, have begun renegotiating workloads, clarifying roles and modelling reasonable hours.

Length count: 78 words from “Many” onwards.

— END OF ANSWER SCHEME —